Leadership Tool: Transitioning and New Leaders Guide to The First 60 Days

Transitioning into a new leadership position can be both an exciting and daunting experience. To navigate this critical period effectively, a structured plan can serve as an invaluable tool for new leaders. The following 60-day plan offers a comprehensive framework designed to provide guidance and best practices for newly appointed leaders. However, it is crucial to recognize that this plan should be used as a flexible guide rather than a rigid directive. Leaders must exercise their judgment to adapt the schedule to their specific organizational context and team dynamics. Different environments and challenges will require varying degrees of strictness in following the schedule, and the ability to adjust the approach based on situational needs is essential for successful leadership.

The initial phase of this plan focuses on learning and fact gathering, which sets the foundation for informed decision-making and effective leadership. For instance, on Day 1, sending out an initial email to the team serves multiple purposes: it introduces the leader in their new role, encourages open lines of communication, fosters a positive culture from the beginning, and helps to alleviate any anxiety the team might be feeling. Subsequent days involve reviewing the organization's mission and vision, familiarizing oneself with company policies, meeting with direct supervisors to clarify expectations, and understanding the financial landscape through budget and revenue review. This structured approach ensures that new leaders gain a comprehensive understanding of their environment, which is critical for making informed decisions and setting the stage for future success. By using this plan as a guide and adapting it to their unique circumstances, new leaders can build a strong foundation for effective leadership and team collaboration.

Phase 1: Learning and Fact Gathering

Day 1: **Send Out an Initial Email to the Team**
This is an opportunity to (1) introduce yourself in the new role; (2) encourage the team to open lines of communication with you; (3) engage with creating a positive culture from the beginning; and (4) ease any tension/anxiety the team might be feeling.

Day 2: **Review Organizational Mission and Vision**
Understand the core values and long-term goals of the organization or department.

Day 3: **Review Company Policies**
Familiarize yourself with HR policies and procedures. This will provide boundaries for both decision making and opportunities for flexibility.

Day 4: **Meet with Your Direct Supervisor**
Clarify expectations and key responsibilities. This will provide insight into short, medium, and long term goals. This is a fact gathering activity so ask questions and practice active listening.

Day 5: **Review Financial Reports**
Understand the budget, revenue streams, and expenses. Knowing the resources you have will help to both make decisions and gather information about revenue streams in the future.

Phase 2: Setting Some Initial Practices and Learning

Day 6: **Establish Communication Channels**
Ensure effective communication methods are in place. Let your team know how they can reach you and how often you hope to hear from them (be careful not to micromanage the team).

Day 7: **Create an Open-Door Policy**
Encourage open communication and accessibility. Set boundaries for when the team has access to you. Best practice is to have "listening hours/sessions."

Day 8: **Understand Current Projects**
Review ongoing projects and their statuses. Meet with a few team members to better understand the current projects that are happening withing the organization/department.

Day 9: **Establish One-on-One Meetings with Team Members**
Start with direct reports and key team members.

Day 10: **Understand Team Roles**
During one-on-one meetings learn about each team member's responsibilities.

Day 11: **Schedule Regular Check-Ins**
After one-on-one meetings establish a routine for regular one-on-one check-ins. This will depend on the dynamics and role of the team member.

Day 12: **Plan a Team Activity**
Plan a training or social event to get to know your team on both a personal and professional level. Allow them to build a relationship with you to encourage open communication and trust.

Day 13: **Observe Team Dynamics**
Attend team meetings or project and observe interactions. Come from a learner perspective to better understand the dynamics of the team.

Day 14: **Identify Informal Leaders**
Recognize team members who influence others.

Phase 3: Build Relationships

Day 15: **Identify Key Stakeholders**
List internal and external stakeholders critical to success.

Day 16: **Engage with External Stakeholders**
Schedule meetings with key clients or partners on the list to gain insight into the relationship, opportunities, and a network for problem solving.

Day 17: **Meet with Peer Leaders**
Set up at least 3 meetings with peer leaders to understand their perspectives and build alliances.

Day 18: **Understand Team Challenges**
Formally or informally ask team members about their biggest challenges. Practice active listening.

Day 19: **Communicate Regular Updates**

This is a great opportunity to communicate an update to your team on the insight you found from your meetings. Keep it positive to maintain momentum.

Phase 4: Initial Meeting to Gather Information

Day 20: **Create a Roadmap**

Create a Roadmap for the next 40 days. You can share this with the team at the end of the introductory meeting. The roadmap should include general thoughts on a vision and the process to achieve goals (not the goals at this point).

Day 21: **Host a Team Introduction Session**

- ***Celebrate the Past*** **–** Start the meeting by recognizing the great work that was done prior to you taking on the new role. Learn about what the team appreciates about the past. This can include successes, culture, etc. Even if the past had difficulty there are still things to appreciate.
- ***Conduct a SWOT Analysis***- Identify strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats.
- ***Share Your General Vision for the Team and Steps Forward***

Phase 5: Identifying Goals and Accountability Measures

Day 22: Finalize SWOT Analysis

Take some time today to finalize the SWOT Analysis based on what was discussed during or after the meeting**.**

Day 23: **Develop a Strategic Vision**

Create a compelling vision for the team's future.

Day 24: Establish Strategic, Tactical and Operational Goals - Align Goals with Organizational Objectives

Ensure team goals support the broader mission.

Day 25: **Set Short-Term Goals**

Establish immediate priorities for the team.

Day 26: **Develop an Action Plan**

Create a detailed plan for the next 40 days.

Day 27: **Prioritize Tasks**

Identify high-impact tasks and focus on them.

Day 28: **Identify Quick Wins**

Focus on easy-to-achieve goals that have a big impact.

Day 29: **Establish Milestones**

Set key milestones to track progress.

Day 30: **Set Performance Metrics**

Define how success will be measured.

Day 31: **Create Accountability Structures**

Think through the mechanisms to ensure accountability.

Phase 6: Setting Expectations

Day 32: **Host a Team Meeting**

Based on all the information you collected and the initial SWOT Analysis, host a team meeting to begin the conversation on vision, goals, communication, responsibilities, and accountability. Remember, many of these aspects will already be in place. This is an opportunity to communicate and share your thoughts to establish a common understanding for moving forward to achieve goals.

- ***Communicate the Vision*** - Share the strategic vision with the team.
- ***Set Long-Term Goals/Objectives*** - Define clear, achievable long-term goals.
- ***Review Team Capacity*** **-** Assess if the team has the resources to meet goals.
- ***Communicate Expectations*** - Clearly articulate performance expectations.
- ***Delegate Responsibilities*** - Assign tasks based on team members' strengths.
- ***Set Performance Standards*** - Define clear performance criteria for the team.
- ***Implement Performance Tracking*** - Use tools to monitor and assess performance.
- ***Implement a Quick Win*** - Execute a task that can be completed quickly.
- ***Implement Feedback Loops*** - Create ways for team members to provide feedback.

Phase 7: Leading By Example

Day 33: **Align Resources with Goals**

Based on conversations from the meeting ensure the team has the necessary resources to achieve the goals.

Day 34: **Assess Team Skills**

Identify strengths and development areas of team members to achieve goals.

Day 35: **Plan Training and Development**

Create development plans for team members.

Day 36: Individually or Collectively Communicate Training and Development

Engage your team in the process of growth to set the foundation for continued development.

Day 37: **Assess Current Culture**

Understand the existing team culture.

Day 38: **Promote Work-Life Balance**

Take some time to communicate and act on the importance of work-life balance. While this is something you will need to engage in everyday, today is an opportunity to do something intentional.

Day 39: **Identify Potential Challenges**

Take some time to think through and anticipate obstacles or challenges that might occur with short term goals. Additionally, plan mitigation strategies. May include a few individuals from the team in this process.

Day 40: **Promote Collaboration**

Based on the potential challenges encourage teamwork and knowledge sharing to mitigate problems (possible connections and email to share expectations).

Day 41: **Encourage Innovation**

Based on the potential challenges support creative problem-solving and new ideas (communicate expectations).

Day 42: Meet with Your Direct Supervisor

This is a good time to provide an update on the first 40 days and actions being taken. Once again, ask questions and practice active listening.

Day 43: Engage with External Stakeholders

This is a good time to provide an update on the first 40 days and actions being taken.

Day 44: Meet with Peer Leaders

This is a good moment to check in and access the organizational landscape.

Phase 8: Initial Accountability

Day 45: Ask For Updates on Small Wins and Short-Term Goals

Day 46: **Evaluate the Impact**

Measure the success of the quick win.

Day 47: **Host A Meeting to Communicate Short Term Wins and Updates**

Keep the team informed about progress and changes.

- ***Highlight Benefits of Wins*** - Emphasize how early successes align with long-term goals.
- ***Seek Team Input on Wins*** - Involve the team in identifying future quick wins.
- ***Plan Additional Quick Wins*** - Identify more opportunities for early success.

Phase 9: Following Up After Accountability

Day 48: **Celebrate the Win**

Publicly recognize the achievement to boost morale (find a way to communicate short term wins and those responsible to key stakeholders).

Day 49: **Adjust Strategies If Needed**

Based off of team feedback, which goals are struggling? What strategies might need to be adjusted based on this new data?

Day 50: **Encourage Skill Building**

Find time today to promote continuous learning and development based on information collected and initial goal outcomes.

Day 51: **Promote Collaboration and Innovation**

Continue to build collaboration and innovation based on goal update to mitigate any issues.

Day 52: **Recognize and Utilize Talents**

Leverage the unique strengths of team members.

Day 53: **Review Long-Term Goals**

Take time to access if long-term goals need to be adjusted based on insight from short term goal outcomes.

Day 54: **Define Desired Culture**

Identify the cultural attributes you want to promote.

Day 55: **Meet Individually with Team Members on Short Term Goals**

Offer guidance and support to team members.

Day 56: **Provide Feedback to Stakeholders on Short Term Goals**

Continue to loop in all stakeholders throughout the process to ensure transparency in goals.

Day 57: **Thank Your Team**

Update your team on insights gained from stakeholders and thank them for their work

Phase 10: Collect Feedback:

Day 58: **Gather Anonymous Feedback**

Use surveys or suggestion boxes for honest input.

- ***Review Communication Effectiveness*** - Assess if the communication strategy you are utilizing is working on both a team and individual level.
- ***Review Process and Expectations*** - Evaluate performance data to ensure both the process and the goals are fair, balanced and achievable.
- ***Assess the Culture*** – Determine if the team believes the culture is headed in the right direction and what suggestions they have to improve upon current plan.

Day 59: **Reflect on the First 60 Days**

Assess what has been achieved and what needs improvement based on the survey and other information collected.

Day 60: **Review Personal Development**

Reflect on your growth as a leader and plan further development.

Phase 11: Moving Forward

Day 61: **Maintain Momentum**

Keep the team motivated by planning the next steps.

Day 62: Go Back to Day 45 and repeat the process

Use your judgment here. Make sure to not over survey the team about progress (Day 58), only doing this officially 2-3 times a year, but it is always important to be collecting informal feedback to adjust and make changes.

ANYTIME, ALL THE TIME

The following are activities that you can do anytime (all the time) to benefit the team and engage in effective leadership. If you are unsure what to do for a certain day, just pick one of these.

- ***Evaluate Development Progress*** - Regularly review and adjust team member development plans.
- ***Communicate Cultural Values*** - Share the desired cultural values with the team.
- ***Communicate Successes*** - Share successes with the team and broader organization.
- ***Communicate Performance Expectations*** - Ensure team members understand what is expected of them.
- ***Provide Regular Feedback*** - Offer constructive feedback to guide improvement.
- ***Recognize and Reward Performance*** **–** Let people know how much you appreciate them and/or the work they have accomplished (be authentic).
- ***Address Performance Issues*** **–** Engage in communication any time a performance issue arises. The quicker you can address it the better.
- ***Gather Team Feedback*** **–** Informally gather information about the team, the culture, communication and opportunities to improve.
- ***Celebrate Milestones*** - Recognize accomplishments and celebrate successes.
- ***Thank Your Team*** - Express gratitude to your team for their support and hard work.